

## CHAPTER TWELVE

# CIVIL SOCIETY ACTIVE DIALOGUE NETWORKS IN CYPRUS: PEACE-ING IT TOGETHER AT THE GRASSROOTS

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### Introduction

The Cyprus problem has long attracted the attention of scholars, researchers, politicians and international organizations. Nevertheless, even the most static, protracted and normalized conflicts are not immune to the dynamic nature of society, identity and Realpolitik. Despite many obstacles, including external factors and the large number of players, finding a comprehensive solution to the Cyprus conflict is imperative. In addition, an understanding of the Cyprus problem can help advance the peace-building and reconciliation literature for at least five main reasons:

- (1) The prolongation of the conflict involves multiple human rights violations for the people of Cyprus. The accession of the Republic of Cyprus (RoC) to the European Union (EU) without the inclusion of the Turkish Cypriots and prior to a comprehensive settlement has placed the conflict within the borders of the EU. It also presents a significant challenge for EU governance across a diverse range of issues, and especially for the EU's objective of achieving stability in the eastern Mediterranean (Christou, 2012);
- (2) The conflict has significant ramifications for the relationship between NATO and the EU. Competing claims over the offshore gas resources in Cyprus, and the fact that Turkey's geographical location as an

important corridor for gas and oil transmission to the EU have implications for EU energy policy;<sup>1</sup>

- (3) Although one can be sceptical about the Turkish governing party AKP's (*Adalet ve Kalkınma Partisi* - Justice and Development Party) intentions with regards to full EU membership, the non-resolution of the Cyprus conflict presents an obstacle for Turkey's EU accession;
- (4) The peace negotiations that were re-launched in 2008 effectively stalled when the RoC assumed the EU presidency in 2012. The peace talks were re-initiated briefly in early 2014; however they were once more postponed indefinitely when the President of the RoC withdrew from UN sponsored negotiations between the Greek and Turkish Cypriot leaderships, claiming a violation of Cyprus' Exclusive Economic Zone by the Turkish seismic vessel *Barbaros* (A. Anastasiou, 2015);
- (5) The ongoing financial crises and economic concerns of the communities have gradually pushed the Cyprus problem down the list of priorities (Eurobarometer, 2013, 2014). Unemployment, inflation and increasing crime rates are now seen as more important. Consequently, frustrations over more immediate challenges within the communities are shifting attention away from the Cyprus problem, and reconfiguring the political dynamics on the island, leading to even deeper uncertainty.

Numerous diplomatic efforts have been made to produce peaceful reunification (H. Anastasiou, 2008). Over the decades, myriad negotiations and peace-talks have begun and have stalled, and were then perhaps fast-tracked and revisited. There is a substantial literature on the Cyprus problem; the material focusing on identity, ethnicity, EU accession, and conflict resolution are very rich (See Aktar et al., 2010; H. Anastasiou, 2008; Christou, 2010; Constantinou, 2007; Diez and Tocci, 2009; Gürkaynak, 2007; Hatay and Bryant, 2008; Michael, 2007; Turk, 2006; Volkan, 2008; Wolleh, 2001). However, this by no means indicates that all aspects, angles and approaches have been covered and addressed. For example, some of the areas where the literature can be enriched and deepened are: the socio-dynamics of the willingness of people in civil society to co-operate and work together; the influence and impact of civil society on Track One level diplomacy;<sup>2</sup> the transformation of civil society

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<sup>1</sup> [http://europa.eu/rapid/press-release\\_MEMO-07-219\\_en.htm](http://europa.eu/rapid/press-release_MEMO-07-219_en.htm)

<sup>2</sup> Multi-Track Diplomacy is a conceptual way to view the process of international peace-making, focusing on the interconnectedness of different activities, individuals, institutions, and communities involved in reconciliation. As it will be discussed later on in the chapter, the multi-track diplomacy approach is based on

following Cyprus' EU accession; the interaction between local and migrant identities and their effects on reconciliation; the general impact of immigration on perceptions of nationalism and ethnic identity; and the effects of the recent regional dynamics (in the EU, the Middle East and Turkey) on the Cyprus problem.

As the literature and scholarly work on the Cyprus conflict and Cypriot identities is very rich, it is unnecessary to give an historical account of the Cyprus problem or the development of ethnic identities here. Neither will this chapter delve into a theoretical discussion about the nature of civil society. Rather, the aim is to give a brief account of the key concepts used in this chapter, namely multi-track diplomacy, civil society, and ontological security.<sup>3</sup> Introducing these three key concepts will establish the framework for the underlying argument that civil society initiatives are crucial for peace-making and peace-building in Cyprus, and will set the scene for the empirical material presented in the third and fourth sections.

This chapter has three main objectives. Firstly, it presents a specific and innovative methodological approach to Track Two level peace-building efforts.<sup>4</sup> Secondly, it introduces and demonstrates the relevance of the emerging literature on ontological security to Cyprus. Thirdly, it highlights the importance of "the day after" (as Kyriacou et al., 2009 call it). If there is no civic ownership of the settlement and convergence at the grassroots level, then there is no firm ground on which to build a sustainable peace, endangering the very stability and implementation of any peace agreement.

Following this order, the first section of the chapter sets the scene by introducing the empirical case, the concept of "multi-track diplomacy" and provides a brief account of Cypriot civil society. The second section introduces and reviews the emerging ontological security literature and assesses its utility for conflict resolution and peace-building. In the third and fourth sections, utilizing a methodology that fuses the established theoretical framework with the empirical work, we develop a best practices schema for peace-building efforts at the grassroots level. The

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the works of Joseph Montville (1987), and Louise Diamond and John McDonald (1996)

<sup>3</sup> Individuals, in addition to physical security, also seek ontological security, that is, security of the "self," which is concerned with the identity and biographical continuity of the perceived "self." According to scholars such as Giddens (1991), Mitzen (2006) and Rumelili (2010), ontological security is achieved by routinizing relationships with significant others, and actors therefore become attached to those relationships, which contribute to perpetuation of conflicts.

<sup>4</sup> The various diplomacy tracks are explained in the next section.

third section presents the details of the process and the methodology, while the fourth section analyses the empirical data within the theoretical framework. The chapter concludes by assessing what the analysis contributes to understanding reconciliation efforts and peace-building in Cyprus. The departure point for this is the premise that it is important to empower civil society organizations (CSOs) and actively engage key people and expand participation in peace and reconciliation efforts in order to build a constituency that has the involvement and participation of different groups from both urban and rural communities across the island. While the theoretical foundations presented in the first sections lay the basis for supporting this premise, the empirical case study provides a practitioner's perspective as to how to achieve it.

## **1. Civil Society and Reconciliation**

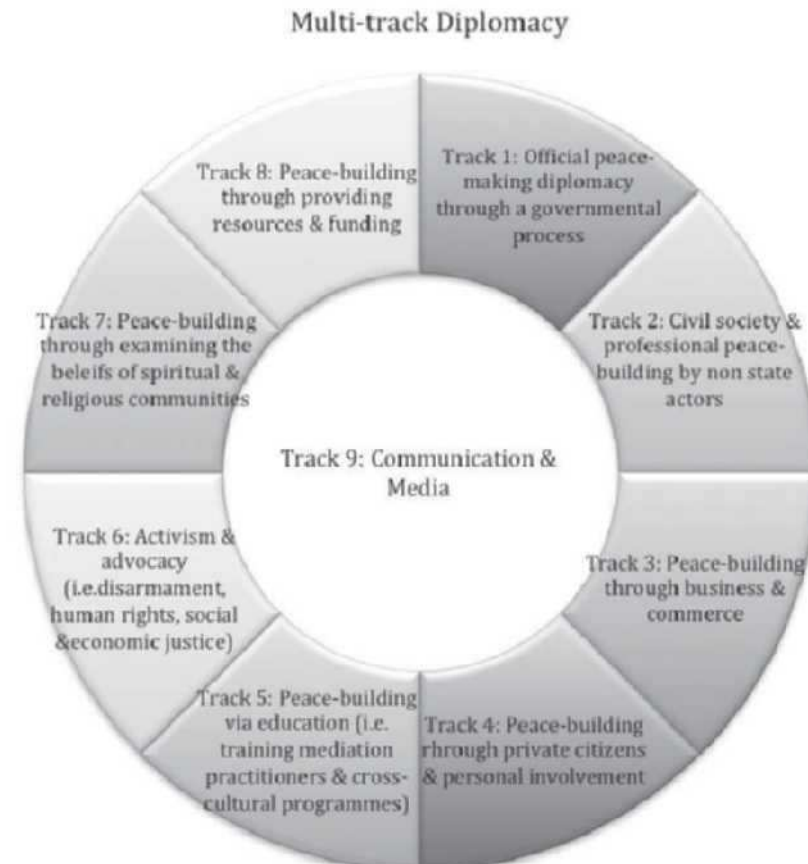
### ***1.1 Why is civil society imperative for peace-building?***

Even though the concept of civil society has a long and distinguished history in Western political theory, the idea remains ambiguous, and “often degenerates into a muddled political slogan” (White, 1994: 376). In general, the genesis of the idea is an idealized counter-image to the state and the market in the realm of freedom and pluralism, “an embodiment of social virtue confronting political vice” (White, 1994: 376). Even though the precise meaning of “civil society” remains elusive in political theory, this general view shows that the concept needs contextualization to become meaningful. While Rakner (1992) limits the concept to organizations which actually interact with the state, Bayart (1986) confines the term to those organizations that embody a confrontational and antagonistic relationship with the state. On the other hand, Foley and Edwards (1996) adopt a wider definition, conceptualizing it as the whole realm of private voluntary associations. Despite these diverse conceptualizations, there is a convergence in the literature that civil society has come to be seen as an essential ingredient for healthy societies (see Cohen, 1994). Especially in liberal democracies, civil society has emerged as a growing third sector as an intermediary between public and private life; an arena outside the sphere of state, business and family but closely interrelated with all of these. This is by no means a new phenomenon, but from a practitioner's perspective it is increasingly important for seeking to build a more just and ethical world. Therefore, for the purposes of this chapter we conceptualize civil society as the sum of all formal or informal groups of people who share common interests and who mobilize for the

public benefit. In our conceptualization, the key ingredient for civil society is *public benefit or common good*; whether institutionalized or not, non-state actors with a common vision and mission working towards some kind of social change or reform for public benefit are included in the definition of “civil society.”

The diplomacy literature helps us locate the relevance and significance of civil society initiatives for conflict resolution and reconciliation. Partly building on the works of Joseph Montville (1987), Louise Diamond and John McDonald (1996) conceptualized multi-track diplomacy systems and identified nine tracks:

**Table 1**



Even though this has become a popular framework in the diplomacy and conflict resolution literature, in practice different tracks can overlap. It may not be easy to distinguish Track Two from Tracks Three and Four, as nongovernmental peace-building initiatives reach out to private citizens and businesses to support their efforts. In small communities such as Cyprus, peace activists tend to be “recycled” for different tracks simultaneously. For example, a bi-communal peace-building project implemented by a consortium of CSOs (Track Two) can work in partnership with a community media centre (Track Nine) to reach out to rural populations (Track Four) in order to engage young people in an exchange program and train them in mediation skills (Track Five), or to reach out to businesses and chambers of commerce to support economic integration through joint ventures (Track Three); as a result, the project presents a needs analysis or an evaluation report to international donors on how to plan future peace-building funding schemes (Track Eight). This blurring of distinctions across tracks however is not important for the purpose of this chapter. The important distinction is that the Track One level comprises political leaders and elites at the state level doing anything from international and domestic decision making to local and global peace-making; while Track Two diplomacy, which at times overlaps with Tracks Three, Four, Five and Six, is about the work of CSOs and nongovernmental professionals, focusing on citizen engagement and bridging the communication gap between society and political elites and institutions.

It is important that all tracks work together in a collaborative and complementary way, as it would be naïve to engage with a protracted conflict solely at the Track One level and expect thereby to garner a sustainable space for peace (See Broome, 1998; Jarraud, 2012; Kyriacou et al., 2009; Lordos et al., 2009; MacGinty et al., 2006 ; Montville, 1987; Zartman, 2007). In line with Diamond and McDonald, Gürkaynak (2007) asserts that Track Two diplomacy relies on a transformation of worldview where basic human needs set the agenda and where collaboration, accessibility and inclusion are central considerations. The main goal is to bring together community members, facilitate a constructive dialogue and support inclusive, creative and sustainable approaches to reconciliation and peace-building. For many scholars within the diplomacy and conflict resolution literature (See Gawerc, 2006; John and Kew, 2008; Marchetti and Tocci, 2009; Orjuela, 2003; Paffenholz and Spurk, 2006; Turk, 2006), Track Two is the bridge between Track One and Three, an essential component of peace-building where the conflict itself has become embedded and ingrained in collective identities. This literature maintains

that the connection established by Track Two (and other tracks) between Track One and the general public helps to support peace-building and rapprochement at the grassroots level without relying solely on the political elite or some outside actor to produce a political settlement. In cases such as Cyprus where official peace-making efforts constantly stall, Track Two is the locomotive that keeps peace-building on the agenda and fights “peace fatigue.”<sup>5</sup> Track Two makes the idea of peace and peace negotiations accessible to the public, which is crucial for creating ownership of what emerges and a strong constituency for peace.

An example of Track One diplomacy in the Cyprus case is the so-called “Annan Plan” process in early 2000s. The Annan Plan, while negotiated on a Track One level and put to simultaneous referenda in 2004, was accepted by the Turkish Cypriot community, but turned down on Track Two and Three levels by the Greek Cypriot community. Whereas there was an extensive mobilization and proactive efforts by Turkish Cypriot civil society in the 2000s, the work being done at the Track Two and Track Three levels in the Greek Cypriot community remained minimal and failed to create support and a strong constituency for the peace plan. For Michális Michael (2007), mediators who interact exclusively with the political elite at Track One at the expense of identifying and engaging in dialogue with opposing voices create a communicative comfort zone that locks the public out and underestimates the force of public opinion (Michael, 2007). Thus, as the Annan Plan was not communicated as a beneficial option for the Greek Cypriot community and no grassroots ownership was created of the specific idea of peace on the table, the result

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<sup>5</sup> It is not uncommon for communities to develop “peace fatigue” in normalized protracted conflicts, or, as Adamides and Constantinou (2011: 242-58) call them, “comfortable conflicts.” By “peace-fatigue” we mean a shift in focus to more mundane and internal problems as people and civil society representatives start feeling disillusioned and disempowered without a tangible achievement at Track One level peace-building efforts. This was prevalent, especially among the Turkish Cypriot community, following the rejection of the Annan Plan by the Greek Cypriot community. The Turkish Cypriots felt that even though they had done everything within their power to change the status quo, a comprehensive settlement was not achieved. Peace fatigue can also be observed by looking at the gap between the desire for a solution and the expectation of one; according to the Cyprus 2015 survey of over 1000 people (conducted in 2011), while 69 percent of Greek Cypriots and 42 percent of Turkish Cypriots stated that they desire a solution, 61 percent and 58 percent respectively said they did not expect the peace process to succeed (Cyprus, 2015).

was an overwhelming “no” vote (75.8% percent) in the 2004 referendum.<sup>6</sup> This is not to suggest that there were no other causes of the “no” vote, but it does present an example of how efforts at the Track Two level are needed to transform public opinion and garner support for peace-making at the Track One level, as happened in Turkish Cypriot civil society.

It should be no surprise that the proposed agreement for a comprehensive settlement after 40 years of protracted conflict failed to find support among the Greek Cypriot community. It had been discussed only at the Track One level, when substantial and encompassing peace-building efforts at the Track Two and Track Three levels were also required. As Track Two focuses on confidence building and the transformation of antagonistic relationships; and as saying “yes” to a comprehensive settlement, means saying “yes” to confronting ingrained societal fears and anxieties, and “yes” to living side by side with the “enemy other,” the importance of Track Two level peace-building for achieving a sustainable comprehensive settlement becomes apparent. Reconciliation is a process of restoring relationships that have been alienated due to conflict, and just as in interpersonal conflicts, reconciliation on a societal level means dealing with a history of relationships, perpetrators, victims, and beneficiaries (Bar-Tal, 2000). The more the various tracks involve and support each other in the peace-building process, the more space there is for reconciliation to develop within and across the communities. In this chapter, we maintain that it is difficult and unsustainable to reconcile on one level without reconciling on the others, a view which will be further supported in the second section’s discussion of the ontological security framework.

### *1.2 Civil society across the divide: Setting the Scene*

Even though the role of civil society has been discussed for centuries (Marchetti and Tocci, 2009), the literature on civil society and its impact on peace-making in Cyprus is thin. The field of conflict resolution, especially in the last decade, has increasingly paid special attention to the role of civil society in intractable conflicts. This trend is easily observable in the way international donors manage and distribute their aid programs through civil society initiatives aimed at conflict resolution and reconciliation. In the context of Cyprus, the main objectives of civil society

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<sup>6</sup> Greek-Cypriot community: Yes: 24.2 percent, No: 75.8 percent, Turnout: 88 percent; Turkish-Cypriot Community: Yes: 64.9 percent, No: 35.1 percent, Turnout: 87 percent (BBC, 2015).

initiatives until the 1990's focused on offering opportunities to members of the communities to develop face-to-face communication and conflict resolution skills. As civil society slowly matured, the initiatives that were focusing on enabling people to develop personal and professional relationships across the Green Line became more specific, especially after the crossing points between the two sides opened in 2003. Joint projects were developed to address shared social, political, environmental and economic concerns (Hadjipavlou, 2012). Irrespective of their "project" objectives, the underlying common goal of these bi-communal civil society efforts was to establish a common vision for the future, where the "us" and "them" and "friend" and "enemy" dichotomies could be transcended or at least mitigated, and the two main communities of the island could come to see the problem from the perspective of the "other." Thus, the overall goal has been to promote rapprochement across the divide, and to help remove the mental barriers that lead to the view that the two communities cannot coexist side by side.

Although many reconciliation efforts and civil society initiatives have been tried over the years, civil society movements have failed to have a significant effect on the course and outcome of the peace negotiations. One of the main recommendations of the CIVICUS State of Civil Society survey (2011) was that capacity building in advocacy and lobbying, establishing effective communication channels between CSOs and public officials and decision-makers, and greater co-operation among CSOs would all enhance civil society's impact at the policy level. This could in turn encourage more people to be actively engaged in CSOs and increase the comprehensiveness of their work as well as their legitimacy. Given the peace fatigue among the Cypriot communities and the demanding nature of the work, it is extremely important to empower CSOs in order to engage more people in their operations and to enhance their lobbying and advocacy activities. Even though there have been some important developments following the opening of the crossing points, such as a significant increase in the number of bi-communal projects<sup>7</sup> (see Mahallae, 2013), the establishment of technical committees (UN 2008), joint action and stronger civil society partnerships between the communities (see AHDR, 2011; CCMC, 2009; CYINDEP, 2006), there is no doubt that the majority of the population on the island is not actively engaged in peace and reconciliation efforts. As previously discussed, this lack of engagement poses a big concern, given the importance of establishing a peace constituency. The CIVICUS survey (2011: 112) found that 50

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<sup>7</sup> Rising from approximately 35 projects in 1995 to over 200 after 2004.

percent of Greek Cypriots and 45 percent of Turkish Cypriots had never visited the other part of the island, and that participation in bi-communal activities remains limited to ten percent for the Greek Cypriot community and 15 percent of the Turkish Cypriot community. The bulk of CSOs are located in the capital, as are the community leaders and the technical committees established under the official negotiations, along with the international organizations engaged in peace-building. Consequently, the involvement of non-state actors away from Nicosia is relatively more difficult and so engagement in peace-building and reconciliation efforts is largely limited to the capital, with the exception of some local initiatives in Famagusta (see Mahallae, 2013). As a result, people outside the Nicosia area have mostly remained detached and distanced from the reconciliation efforts. It is absolutely imperative that more people are engaged in peace and reconciliation efforts and a constituency for peace is built across the island, with the involvement and participation of groups from other towns and rural communities. In their comprehensive analysis of island-wide peace-building activities in Cyprus, Hadjipavlou and Kanol (2008) confirm that the majority of participants in conflict resolution workshops and mediation training came from educated groups who could speak English.<sup>8</sup> As a result, despite having inspiring outcomes and creating a pool of highly skilled individuals equipped to contribute to the peace process, the activities were criticized for being too academic and elitist.

MacGinty, Muldoon, and Ferguson emphasize that “there is often a dissonance between the peace agreed at the elite level and the interpretation and experience of that peace at the group and individual level” (MacGinty et al., 2006). This stresses the importance of having a broad constituency that takes ownership of the move to peace; without it, reconciliation may fail to develop into a transformative peace which allows the underlying causes of conflict to be addressed. The importance of a political agreement for peace-building cannot be overstated; however, what happens “the day after” an agreement (Kyriacou et al., 2009) is equally important. The reason for thinking about “the day after” is to stress the need to provide a feeling of security that the traumas of the past will not reoccur. Whether or not a political agreement will produce an environment of insecurity and fear by asking people to live with those they believed were their existential enemies depends on whether reconciliation at the grassroots level has managed to reconfigure the “self” and “other” dynamic through practices of confidence building and reconciliation. The next section discusses the relationship between the images of “self” and

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<sup>8</sup> English is the common language used in bi-communal initiatives in Cyprus.

“other” and what reconfiguring that relationship might mean, but a metaphor seems apt here: The day after a peace agreement is like marriage after the wedding day; maintaining marital harmony is a long, transformative process where people need to believe that their identities can continue to be different without being threatening, and that they can coexist and develop a sense of shared purpose and a common vision.

Looking at the example of Northern Ireland, Gallagher (2004) points out that people can maintain a level of cross-community interaction without gaining insight into alternative views on the issues that had divided their communities from each other. One particular consequence of this is “that communities in Northern Ireland have a clear sense of the wrong that has been done to them, but little understanding of the sense of victimhood that other communities feel” (Gallagher, 2004: 638). In this respect, Northern Ireland is comparable to Cyprus: since the opening of the crossing points in 2003, increased border crossings and cross-community interaction did not necessarily translate into meaningful understanding and reconfiguration of perceptions of the “other” community. This is apparent from the reactions to a speech made by the Republican Turkish Party (CTP<sup>9</sup>) Member of Parliament Doğuş Derya in parliament on 15 December 2014. She said that Turkish Cypriots were not the only ones losing as a result of the Cyprus conflict, and that there was a need to acknowledge the traumas and sufferings of others. Highlighting the sufferings of Greek Cypriots, Armenians and Maronites, Derya said that the Orthodox Church had allowed abortions for rape victims in 1974, contrary to Orthodox doctrine (See Hadjipavlou 2010). This speech made the headlines the next day, both in Cyprus and in Turkey (Yenidüzen, 2014). The majority of commentary on online platforms, social media and in the mainstream media denied the claims Derya had made and condemned her for being “ignorant” and a “traitor.” Despite the fact that cross-community interaction has been increasing since the opening of the crossing points, this is a sad example which demonstrates that there is still little understanding of “the other” as different but unthreatening, and little recognition of the “other’s” pain.

The argument of this section is that a signed agreement can only ever be a small part of a wider, inclusive and deliberative process of social reconciliation (see Jarraud, 2012; Kay, 2012). The next section develops

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<sup>9</sup> Republican Turkish Party, a left-wing, pro-peace, social democratic political party in the northern part of Cyprus, founded in 1970. The party was led by Mehmet Ali Talat from 1996 until his election as president in 2005.

the concept of ontological security and relates it to questions of identity and peace-building, to further demonstrate the importance of peace ownership at the grassroots level and the role of civil society in achieving sustainable peace.

## **2. Are we scared of peace? Dependency of the “self” on the “other”**

It is easy to want peace, to long for it, but equally difficult to imagine it. Imagining peace means re-imagining the “self” and the “other” in a future full of uncertainties. Peace is conditional: in Cyprus it depends on alleviating the fears and anxieties of the two main communities on the island, but these fears and anxieties are by no means static and homogeneous. Fifty-five years after the establishment of the Republic of Cyprus, over 50 years after communal division, and 40 years after the physical division of the island, life in Cyprus goes on as if it were normal to have the barbed wire of the Green Line looming in the background. Even though the two main communities of the island now can freely travel across the crossing points and have increased their interactions since 2003, thousands of children of the last two generations grew up learning about the existential enemy that lived next door, just across the Green Line. The communities created an image for themselves that depended on the image of the enemy; where all internal was good and just, and all external was bad and evil (see Papadakis et al., 2006; Papadakis, 2008; Spyrou, 2006; Volkan, 2008). Peace-building and reconciliation efforts challenge this image, and hence they challenge our very identities. This is where ontological security comes into play.

According to Giddens (1991: 53), self-identity is “the self as reflexively understood by the person in terms of her or his biography” and identity “presumes continuity across time and space.” Subsequently, he explains ontological security as the confidence the self has in sustaining a “biographical continuity” through establishing a system of basic trust in the real world and in social relations with others. Ontological security is an emotive identification, not always an overt cognitive experience (Noble, 2005); rather it is about the trust we have in the continuity of our self-identity and in our social and material environments of action (Giddens, 1990: 92). This trust shows itself in the routines we adopt that reinforce and reproduce our ontological security. In creating a world to establish our self-identities, reinforced by routines and trust in our personal and material environment, we draw borders to decide what is in and what is out, to decide what is “us” and what is not. Giddens (1991: 42), who notes that

“learning what is not me” is the origin of self-identity, affirms the discursive necessities that make identity dependent on difference.

Drawing largely on Giddens’ work, the concept of ontological security has given birth to a growing body of literature in International Relations (Browning and Joenniemi, 2012; Kinnvall, 2004; Lupovici, 2012; Mitzen, 2006; Roe, 2008; Steele, 2005, 2008; Zarakol, 2010). Even though there is no consensus among IR scholars on whether or not states, collectives or groups are primarily driven by ontological security seeking/producing practices, Mitzen (2006) and Steele (2005) convincingly argue that communities care about their ontological security at least as much as their physical security.

Self-identity is the anchor for ontological security and the foundational pillar of our biographic continuity. Rumelili (2004) and Mitzen (2006) support this view of identity construction, maintaining that identity is dependent on difference. Building on Giddens’ understanding of the link between self-identity and routines, Rumelili (2015) stresses that identity is constituted not through just any routine, but specifically through those that articulate difference and distinctiveness. For Behnke (2006), identities cannot exist without self/other distinctions, and actors constantly produce and reproduce their identities (be they national, ethnic, religious etc.) through discourses of security.

As long as identity has boundaries (whether flexible or rigid), there are those that are included and those that are excluded: those that are excluded are different to the “self” for some reason. Perhaps they represent an old self, a worse self or an “other.” McSweeney (1999: 15) sees ontological security as a “property of a relationship, a quality making each secure in the other.” However, what makes the self secure in the other could be a negative relationship of enmity and hostility as well as a positive one of friendship and harmony (Roe 2008; Rumelili 2013). Browning and Joenniemi (2012) emphasize that although actors need to distinguish themselves from other actors to be able to exist, difference need not always appear as negative. Adopting a relationist approach, this chapter maintains that identity depends on self/other relations, where the construction of self is based on difference and the interaction of self with “others,” cumulatively creating a biographical narrative of the self; however, this construction is “not destined to translate into mutually exclusive and incompatible categories of subjectivity” (Browning and Joenniemi, 2012: 493). This means that identity based on difference does not have to translate into a relationship of *othering* and perception of the “other” as threatening.

In protracted conflicts, identities are configured and reproduced based on an image of an existential enemy. As such, the conflict itself and the relationship with the enemy can reinforce the sense of ontological security because the “self” is dependent upon this relationship with the “enemy other,” where trust in the biographical continuity of the self becomes ingrained in the conflict-producing routines themselves. Removing the “enemy other” from the intrinsic identity definitions of the self could leave the self ontologically insecure. Confidence building measures (CBMs) that consider intricate nuances of identity and the role of ontological security in peace-building can ensure that self-identity based on difference does not translate into a relationship of enmity or *othering*.

According to Sigel (1989: 459), “There exists in humans a powerful drive to maintain the sense of one’s identity, a sense of continuity that allays fear of changing too fast or being changed against one’s will by outside forces.” This drive is what makes all actors ontological security seekers. As actors feel existential anxiety, it is not uncommon for them to wish to reaffirm their self-identity or become compulsively attached to their routines. A critical situation that causes ontological insecurity may arise from deep uncertainty (Mitzen, 2006), such as a sudden change in the identity definitions that tie the self to the objective world, or failure to have the self acknowledged and affirmed by others (B. McSweeney, 1996; Zarakol, 2010). A peace agreement at the Track One level without reconciliation at the other tracks is an example of a critical situation that creates uncertainty because it essentially reconfigures the enemy as the new compatriot, requiring a sudden change in identity definitions, where the threatening other becomes part of the “self.”

In such a state of uncertainty and insecurity, actors are tempted to engage in practices of *othering* to re-affirm the identity of the self, where the other is seen as not only different, but also inferior and threatening (Campbell, 1998). The self is tempted to fortify the borders of its identity, more often than not by turning to exclusivist rhetoric to differentiate between members and non-members of the in group in order to reassure itself of the boundary between them. In such situations of intensified anxiety, actors resort to xenophobic, fundamentalist and populist accounts of nationalism and religion as an ontological security-seeking strategy (Browning and Joenniemi, 2012; Kinnvall, 2004; Roe, 2008).

It is worth noting but not at all surprising that historical sources on Cyprus are contradictory. Since the establishment of the short-lived Republic in 1960 each community has had its own schools, preferred newspapers, political parties, cultural and sport organizations, and preferred version of history that paints the *out-group* as untrustworthy and

aggressive. For Broome (2005: 83) “the past has been distorted beyond recognition by the educational systems and political propaganda of both sides” in Cyprus. For example, while the Greek Cypriot history textbooks focus on the British rule and the events of 1974, Turkish Cypriot history textbooks focus on the Ottoman period and the inter-communal strife before the events of 1974 (Makriyianni and Psaltis, 2007). History education has been based on an “essentialist argument that relies on principles of racial descent” (Papadakis, 2008: 134) as a determinant of identity, which leaves very little room for the self to “choose,” “mould” or “define” its ethnic or national identity in Cyprus. Of course the use of historical narratives to reinforce political legitimacy is by no means unique to Cyprus. In many societies, especially those with ethno-national conflicts, history is often used to propagate a narrative focusing on the suffering of one group in order to legitimate its political goals. In these narratives, the suffering of others is ignored and their historical existence and legitimacy is questioned (Papadakis 2008). There is no doubt that historical propaganda employed in textbooks for the past 40 years has played a big role in Cypriot identity formation and the (mis)perception of the other(s) as illegitimate and antagonistic. Thus, peace negotiations that rely on the reunification of Cyprus based on a bi-communal, bi-zonal federation with political equality, single sovereignty and a single citizenship (UNSC, 2008) automatically challenge the self-narratives and consequently the ontological security of both Greek Cypriots and Turkish Cypriots.

Following LeBaron (2003), Broome et al. (2012) contend that cultural differences affect conflict communication, and that conflicts are not just about territory, boundary, and sovereignty issues but they are also about *acknowledgment, representation, and legitimization of different identities*, as well as ways of *living, being, and making meaning*. Zarakol (2010) and Rumelili (2010) argue that the prospect of peace ideally needs to challenge the fears, deprivations and isolations of groups by bringing them together, but the very process of peace-building and the possibility of a settlement creates a sense of anxiety as it entails the questioning and redefinition of the actors’ understanding of the other and a reconfiguration of group relations. Therefore the anxieties arising from the very prospect of finding a solution need to be channelled constructively to convert the feelings of ontological insecurity they engender into a feeling of ontological security. This analysis points to a gaping hole in the mainstream approach of Track One peace-building, as ignoring ontological (in)security limits its capacity to deal with the affective, emotional, and perceptual realm of peace-building.

The process of peace-building and conflict resolution entails practices that challenge and try to change the narratives of, feelings towards, and understandings of the “other.” The desire to protect a “sense of self” can be the basis from which old conflicts become new (Campbell, 1998), and a peace treaty may fail to transform into a sustainable environment of peace and security owing to a lack of grassroots support. Even though peace-making might be achieved at the “state” level once an agreement on governance is reached among elites, the ontological foundations of the conflict requiring reconciliation at the societal level need to be addressed through civil society initiatives and CBMs that can create a sense of ownership for peace and provide a space to reconfigure self-other relationships in a reflexive manner.

As we have seen, identity and self-narratives are formed and sustained through both material and personal relationships. Actors reproduce ontological security by routinizing their relations with both enemies and friends (Mitzen, 2006). Thus the ultimate attainment of “peace” requires a fundamental transformation of the self, which is not an easy task. According to Kay (2012), insecurities created by peace-making can partly be alleviated by practices that appear epiphenomenal, such as truth commissions and Cold War history panels. These can be essential components of change because they help groups achieve reflexive routinization. Track One level peace-building needs civil society to initiate and sustain reflexive routinization, and confidence building practices that support reconfiguration of collective narratives to address the anxieties that trigger ontological insecurity.

The discussion now turns to the application of one particular process that seeks to produce the transformations necessary to produce ontological security following a peace settlement.

### **3. Methodology: Deliberative Collective Wisdom**

The Peace and Reconciliation Active Dialogue Network (ADN) was established through the “ENGAGE-Do Your Part for Peace”<sup>10</sup> project as a thematic multi-sector representative network. The framework of the network was established to bring together a diverse range of individuals and decision makers to diagnose and discuss issues with regards to peace and reconciliation and subsequently recommend and prioritize CBMs. The Peace and Reconciliation ADN concentrated on discussing the current situation facing Cypriots with the aim of finding a comprehensive solution

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<sup>10</sup> For more on the project see <http://www.mc-med.eu/2012-02-28-09-43-21>

to the Cyprus conflict, the ways to overcome the current deadlock in the negotiations, and specifically the kind of CBMs that would contribute to reconciliation efforts. The main objective of the ADN was to create an alternative civic platform that could openly discuss and suggest confidence-building measures and develop them in a more participatory and deliberative way with grassroots support. These could in turn promote ownership of the process leading towards a sustainable and comprehensive settlement.

The Peace and Reconciliation ADN methodology provides a democratic, participatory and inclusive platform for facilitated dialogue engaging both “more people and key people” in the process. The innovative methodology draws its strength from the “collective wisdom” and “Structured Dialogic Design Process” developed over 30 years by Hasan Ozbekan (1970) and Alecos Christakis (see Christakis and Bausch, 2006) that aims to create consensus among participants, and to design action plans pertaining to a collectively-identified triggering question.<sup>11</sup>

One of the main criticisms of the reconciliation efforts and bi-communal initiatives in Cyprus is that they are limited to Nicosia and fail to incorporate people and perspectives outside the capital. According to the civic map created by the Mahallae initiative, out of 684 bi-communal civil society projects completed between 1979 and 2013, only 49 were implemented by CSOs from outside Nicosia or which had branches outside the capital.<sup>12</sup> There are some underlying reasons for this: most donor organizations are based in the capital; the capital has three out of the seven crossing points on the island; the capital historically has a more lively and dense civil society environment, including trade unions and chambers of commerce; the remarkable peace demonstrations of the early 2000s were mostly mobilized in the capital; in Nicosia the Green Line is only a few metres wide, making crossing more time- and cost-efficient. This creates a sense of dependency on the capital rather than self-reliance of other towns and villages to sustain reconciliation efforts island-wide. The ultimate goal of the ADN was to extend reconciliation efforts beyond Nicosia and to contribute to the peace process in a positive way by

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<sup>11</sup> The methodology is grounded upon 7 laws:

1. Ashby’s Law of Requisite Variety; 2. Miller’s Law of Requisite Parsimony; 3. Boulding’s Law of Requisite Saliency; 4. Peirce’s Law of Requisite Meaning; 5. Tsivacou’s Law of Requisite Autonomy in Decision; 6. Dye’s Law of the Requisite Evolution of Observations; and 7. Laouris’ Law of Requisite Action. For more, see <http://harnessingcollectivewisdom.com/>

<sup>12</sup> For more information on the Mahallae civic map see <http://mahallae.org/project-details-view>

bringing the communities of Cyprus closer together and moving towards a comprehensive solution on the island, and by producing a representative grassroots policy paper that could show the way forward and recommend CBMs prioritized by the two main communities of the island.

The Peace and Reconciliation ADN introduced the work of ENGAGE and bi-communal work to rural communities through ADN meetings and ENGAGE-On-the-Move events. Bridging the gap between rural and urban areas was inherent in the work of the thematic ADNs in general and crucial for the Peace and Reconciliation ADN in particular. One of the main strategies for the ADNs has been their collaboration and co-operation with local authorities and CSOs through rural ADN meetings to ensure ownership, sustainability and greater impact, as well as creating strategic partnerships with rural organizations and local government. By involving local opinion leaders as a means of promoting ownership and empowerment within rural communities, the ADN aspired to build a constituency for peace and to create a more inclusive environment for constructive public deliberation.

The efforts of the ADN started with a bi-communal agenda-setting meeting and continued with eight mono-communal meetings (four in each community) in different locations across the island. The process concluded with a final bi-communal meeting in the Nicosia buffer zone attended by selected representatives from both communities. The mono-communal meetings were particularly significant in involving those who did not feel comfortable in expressing themselves in English. The efforts of the ADN and the subsequent policy paper were followed by a survey of participants that sought to decide on the priority of the various CBMs that had been suggested at the ADN meetings in order to provide a more representative picture of the feelings of participants. The final meeting was used to turn the findings and priorities into tangible action-oriented projects.

The Peace and Reconciliation ADN meetings included 66 Turkish Cypriots and 53 Greek Cypriots and took place in both Nicosia and rural areas.<sup>13</sup> In addition to the face-to-face rural ADN workshops, prioritization exercises were developed using two online surveys, face-to-face questionnaires, and an ad hoc meeting in Famagusta, held in order to open up participation to more individuals to increase inclusivity in order to support and strengthen advocacy efforts. For the sake of methodological cogency and coherence, the charts below focus only on the ADN meeting results. Following the mapping exercises and diagnosis at the ADN

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<sup>13</sup> Rural meetings included Paphos/Baf, Larnaca/Larnaka, Limassol/Leymosun, Deryneia/Derinya, AyiosEpiktitos/Çatalkoy, AyiosSergios/Yeniboğaziçi, Morphou/Güzelyurt and Dikomo/Dikmen

workshops, participants created a list of recommendations based on the issues they had identified. Fifteen CBM recommendations were generated by the Greek Cypriot and 34 by the Turkish Cypriot participants. The ADN participants were then asked to prioritize these and then vote (individually) for the five recommendations that they thought were the most urgent and that would best facilitate progress. The prioritization exercises were done mono-communally for the recommendations generated by the participants of each community; the common priority CBM analysed in this chapter was independently recommended and prioritized by both communities.

The two tables below show the top five CBMs prioritized by the ADN participants. It should be noted that the greater consensus among Greek Cypriot participants is mainly due to the smaller number of recommended CBMs.

#### 4. Analysis of the Findings

The policy paper that was drafted, based on the priorities set as a result of the votes in each meeting and the contributions from the survey participants, garnered widespread support both from ADN participants and from the project associates and local partners. The three issues that gathered the most votes among Cypriots were:

- **Island-wide Priority:** *Translation of all formal documents and signs related to central and local government offices into Turkish and translation of all road signs into three languages.* 23 percent of Turkish Cypriots and 51 percent of Greek Cypriots voted for this priority.
- **Turkish Cypriot Community Priority:** *The Turkish Cypriot community should be included in the EU Customs Union, ports should be opened under EU supervision, Varosha should be handed over to UN-EU supervision and Turkey should open its ports to the Republic of Cyprus.* 46% percent voted for this priority.
- **Greek Cypriot Community Priority:** *Design a new campaign to promote the benefits of reconciliation: “Seeing through bi-communal lenses.”* 60 percent voted for this priority.

**The island-wide Priority:** *Translation of all formal documents and signs related to central and local government offices into Turkish and translation of all road signs into three languages (Turkish, Greek and English).*

**Table 2**

| Top Five TC Priorities                                                                                                                                                                                                                              | Core Group | Guzelyurt/ Morphou | Yenibogazici/ Ayios Seryios | Catalkoy/ Ayios Epiktitos | Dikmen / Dikomo | Total % |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|--------------------|-----------------------------|---------------------------|-----------------|---------|
| TCc should be included in the EU Customs Union, the Ports should be opened under EU supervision, Turkey should open its ports to the RoC, Turkey's negotiations process should move forward, and Varosha should be handed over to UN-EU supervision | 100%       | 83.3%              | 27.8%                       | 30.0%                     | 26.1%           | 267.2   |
| GSM operators to work on both sides of the island                                                                                                                                                                                                   | 100%       | 16.7%              | 38.9%                       | 20.0%                     | 26.1%           | 201.7   |
| Preparation of common history books                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | 44.4%      | 50.0%              | 33.3%                       | 30.0%                     | 17.4%           | 175.2   |
| Cooperation on natural reserves and energy (water, natural gas, electricity, etc.)                                                                                                                                                                  | 22.2%      | 33.3%              | 22.2%                       | 60.0%                     | 21.7%           | 159.5   |
| Translation of all formal documents and signs related to central and local government offices into Turkish                                                                                                                                          | 44.4%      | 33.3%              | 16.7%                       | 0.0%                      | 43.5%           | 137.9   |
| <b>Number of participants</b>                                                                                                                                                                                                                       | 9          | 6                  | 18                          | 10                        | 23              | 66      |

| Top 5 GC Priorities                                                                                                                                     | Core Group | Larnaca / Larnaka | Paphos / Baf | Limassol / Limasol | Derynia / Derinya | Total % |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|-------------------|--------------|--------------------|-------------------|---------|
| A new campaign to promote benefits of reconciliation: "seeing through bi-communal lenses"                                                               | 75.0%      | 88.9%             | 100.0%       | 100.0%             | 100.0%            | 463.9   |
| Translation of all formal documents and signs related to central and local government offices into Turkish                                              | 83.3%      | 83.3%             | 87.5%        | 75.0%              | 85.7%             | 414.9   |
| Design of a joint strategy for a new peace process that includes all stakeholders                                                                       | 75.0%      | 39.0%             | 100.0%       | 87.5%              | 71.4%             | 372.8   |
| Introduction of Greek and Turkish languages to formal and non-formal education environments                                                             | 83.3%      | 50.0%             | 75.0%        | 75.0%              | 85.7%             | 369.0   |
| Organise visit by GCc/TCc civil society to high profile bodies (i.e. Turkish/Greek government officials, TCc/GCc authorities, EU institutions and etc.) | 50.0%      | 83.3%             | 37.5%        | 50.0%              | 57.1%             | 278.0   |
| <b>Number of participants</b>                                                                                                                           | 12         | 18                | 8            | 8                  | 7                 | 53      |

The results of the prioritization exercise gave this as the top recommendation by both Greek Cypriot and Turkish Cypriot ADN participants.<sup>1</sup>

This island-wide priority is important for both communities for numerous reasons, including trust building, practicality and legal considerations. Article 3 of the 1960s constitution states that the official languages of the Republic of Cyprus are Greek and Turkish, and that all official documents must be published in both languages. However, even though it is possible to find some documents in Turkish many others are still published only in Greek. Ensuring that all official documents are published in Turkish will allow easier access to the institutions and authorities of the Republic of Cyprus for Turkish Cypriots and will fulfil the legal provisions of the 1960s constitution of the Republic of Cyprus. In addition, it will create a stronger sense of a multilingual society and diminish the difficulties created by language barriers. Furthermore, the translation of road signs into three languages will have many positive impacts on the two communities island-wide. Implementation and promotion of this CBM in the Turkish Cypriot community is particularly significant for the Greek Cypriot community and will symbolize that the cultural heritage of the island is protected.

Translation of documents and road signs is important as it demonstrates a common interest in reunifying the island. Apart from being a sign of good will, the trilingual road signs will make the lives of drivers easier. Furthermore, the visibility of such an action will be strong and long-lasting. Even though there are concerns with regards to the cost of this recommendation, the Peace and Reconciliation ADN together with its local partners can achieve it through small steps and pilot projects taken in close collaboration with the local authorities. The success of pilot projects will create a snowball effect inspiring both donors and decision makers to pursue similar initiatives.

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<sup>1</sup> In the prioritization exercise for the Turkish Cypriot community, 27 percent of ADN participants (44 percent of the Core Group, 33 percent of Morphou, 17 percent of Ayios Seryios, none of Ayios Epiktitos, 43 percent of Dikomo and 22 percent of Famagusta participants) voted for this priority. In the Greek Cypriot community, 83 percent of ADN participants (83 percent each of the Core Group and Larnaca, 88 percent of Paphos, 75 percent of Limassol and 86 percent of Deryneia participants) voted for this priority.

**The Turkish Cypriot Community Priority:** *The Turkish Cypriot community should be included in the EU Customs Union; ports should be opened under EU supervision; Varosha should be handed over to UN-EU supervision and Turkey should open its ports to the Republic of Cyprus.*<sup>2</sup>

The majority of the Peace and Reconciliation ADN members agreed that the inclusion of the Turkish Cypriot Community in the EU Customs Union would promote economic integration within the island and facilitate a sustainable and comprehensive solution to the protracted problem. The ADN members thought that the ports in the northern part of Cyprus should be opened to international traffic under EU supervision, which will necessitate the concurrent opening of ports and the airspace of Turkey to the Republic of Cyprus, thus improving the Turkey-EU negotiations process and be a move towards normalizing Turkey-Republic of Cyprus relations. The ADN members added that Varosha should be handed over to the United Nations, as clearly stated in various Security Council Resolutions,<sup>3</sup> in order for it to be re-opened and returned to its original inhabitants with both United Nations and European Union assistance. This would not only create economic growth and investment in the town, but would also contribute significantly to a comprehensive settlement. By building trust, with good planning and vision, a revitalized Varosha could become a model of synergy and coexistence. The ADN participants agreed that these three measures were inter-connected and should be advocated as a package to help bring about a breakthrough in the stalled peace negotiations.

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<sup>2</sup> According to the prioritization exercise 49 percent of the ADN participants (100 percent of the Core Group, 83 percent of Morphou, 28 percent of Ayios Seryios, 30 percent Ayios Epiktitos, 26 percent Dikomo and 28 percent of Famagusta participants) 45 percent of the online survey respondents and 25 percent of the face-to-face questionnaire respondents voted for this priority.

<sup>3</sup> See UNSC S/RES/550 1984, UNSC S/RES/789 1992 and UNSC S/RES/902 1994

**The Greek Cypriot Community Priority:** *A new campaign called "Seeing through bi-communal lenses" which aims to promote the benefits of reconciliation.*<sup>4</sup>

This priority received great attention as it emerged as a result of a deliberative process at the grassroots level; and it directly reflects the needs and interests of voices that had hitherto been missing, as the majority of participants did not have any previous bi-communal experience. The campaign of "seeing through bi-communal lenses" would investigate and promote the benefits of reconciliation, (including the economic ones) by targeting strategic audiences. The participants stressed the importance of short-term small accomplishments and the need for a well-focused effort to demonstrate both sides' commitment to peace.

Nevertheless, the participants in the process expressed two main cautions. The first was in relation to the cost of some of the priorities, such as the translation of signs and documents; and the second concerned doubts about the efficacy of targeting priorities that could be implemented by local communities and local authorities without endorsement from political leaders and elites, whose lack of support could hinder and significantly slow down the efforts of the ADN.

Advocating the priorities of the ADNs is important for bridging the gap between Track One and Track Two level peace-building and for maintaining the momentum and motivation for the continuation of the reconciliation efforts on the island. This is not only the will of the Cypriot communities as evidenced by the work of the ADNs and other public opinion polls<sup>5</sup> but is also the will of the international community that desires to see a peaceful and reunited island.<sup>6</sup> For Cyprus to achieve peace and stability, the active participation in the process of as many people as

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<sup>4</sup> In the prioritization exercise, 80 percent of ADN participants (75 percent of Core Group, 89 percent of Larnaca, 63 percent of Paphos, 75 percent of Limassol and 100 percent of Deryneia participants), 66 percent of the online survey respondents and 74 percent of the ad hoc Nicosia meeting participants have voted for this priority.

<sup>5</sup> For example, see Centre for Sustainable Peace and Democratic Development <http://www.seedsofpeace.eu/> (Cyprus, 2015)

<sup>6</sup> See the statements and mandates of various international organisations, such as UN Peacekeeping Force in Cyprus <http://www.betterworldcampaign.org/un-peacekeeping/missions/cyprus.html>; The European Commission Representation in Cyprus [http://ec.europa.eu/cyprus/index\\_en.htm](http://ec.europa.eu/cyprus/index_en.htm); or The EU Observer <https://euobserver.com/foreign/123097>.

possible is crucial. This would mean that the political negotiations at the Track One level are complemented with a parallel process of grassroots reconciliation and confidence building through representative and inclusive civil society efforts.

## Conclusion

### *How do the results from ADNs relate to the theoretical framework?*

The findings presented in the case study are parallel to the theoretical framework that identifies feelings of security, self-identity and trust as the main pillars of achieving sustainable peace. The island-wide priority, which recommended that road signs should be translated into three languages, would demonstrate a will to recognize the distinct identity of each community and at the same time build trust by allowing the use of each other's language out of respect, as well as for convenience. This priority comports well with the view that "ontological security is an emotive identification and not always an overt cognitive experience" (Noble, 2005), as it is about the trust we have in the continuity of our self-identity and in our social and material environments of action (Giddens, 1990: 92). By changing road signs and official documents we can, in part, transform daily routines that reinforce and reproduce our ontological security by inserting a part of the "other's" identity into those routines and material environment.

Furthermore, achieving progress on the Turkish Cypriot priority would contribute to the elimination of the security concerns of Turkish Cypriots. It would alleviate their sense of isolation by allowing them to integrate into the international community and provide them with a sense of legitimacy, while also addressing the fear of both communities of the potential escalation of the conflict. This is in line with the argument that conflicts are not only about territorial, boundary, and sovereignty issues, but also about *acknowledgment, representation, and legitimization of different identities*, as well as ways of *living, being, and making meaning* (LeBaron, 2003; Broome et al., 2012). The normalization of relations between the Republic of Cyprus and Turkey would go a long way to reduce fears of conflict escalation.

The Greek Cypriot priority of an awareness campaign to inform people about the benefits of achieving peace would address the fear of "losing out" both economically and politically, as well as their fears about Turkey (see Faustmann, 2004). This is in line with the contention that if the

prospect of peace challenges the fears and deprivations of groups by bringing them together, and the very process of peace-building and the possibility of a settlement thus creates a sense of anxiety and ontological insecurity, then this confidence-building priority would constructively channel the prospect of finding a solution to move from a feeling of ontological insecurity to one of security (Zarakol, 2010, Rumelili 2010).

The categorical difference between the Greek Cypriot and Turkish Cypriot priorities (one being relatively vague; the other more ambitious) is a reflection of the different ontological security needs of the two communities. As demonstrated in the Annan Plan referendum, the Greek Cypriots are not sure if any accord with the Turkish Cypriots will make them better off, and they are concerned not to risk what they have secured as the legitimate government of Cyprus. Their ontological security rests on this legitimacy and sovereignty that has provided them with biographical continuity and safety for their self-identity. Therefore, the ADN participants suggested seeking to alleviate the fears of the Greek Cypriots by having members of their own community explain to them the benefits of a solution, especially as some of the ADN participants themselves were unsure of what might happen and therefore very cautious. Turkish Cypriots, on the other hand, as they demonstrated in the Annan Plan referendum, are eager to reach a solution that will legitimize their current self-government in their own territory and also help maintain their distinct Turkish Cypriot identity by lifting the isolation they face as a result of non-recognition. Their ontological security is challenged by lack of legitimacy and recognition, which in turn challenges their biographical continuity as Turkish Cypriots. Thus their priority seeks to remedy their ontological insecurities.

It would not be an oversimplification to say that both sides want to consolidate what they already have. However, their initial positions diverge. Since the Annan Plan, the Greek Cypriots in general believe they will allay their fears and secure their hegemony over Cyprus by not accepting a new partnership agreement. Turkish Cypriots on the other hand, in general believe they will manage to keep what they already have and not lose their identity and self-rule. Maintaining appropriate distance from domination by either the Greek Cypriots or Turkey would be achieved by signing an agreement which would be accepted by the Greek Cypriots and endorsed by both Turkey and the international community. The different ontological security needs can explain the ambitious highly politicized CBMs proposed by the Turkish Cypriot participants and vague and low profile CBMs proposed by Greek Cypriot participants. It is perhaps not coincidental that, as we were writing this chapter the Turkish

Cypriots once again demonstrated their strong will to solve the Cyprus problem by electing a new leader Mustafa Akıncı as their President. Akıncı based his campaign on achieving a comprehensive solution to the Cyprus Problem, supporting CBMs, and indicating his support for the opening of Varosha for its original owners and giving some kind of legitimacy to the port of Famagusta and Ercan airports and opening them to use by all Cypriots. Soon after his election the talks between the two sides restarted with a more positive atmosphere on both sides of the green line.

In summary, failing to understand and consider the nuances of identity and its connection to ontological security, plus the latter's link with peace-building has kept the Cyprus problem deadlocked for over four decades. Peace building and reconciliation efforts in Cyprus have also suffered from peace fatigue, failed to achieve tangible outcomes at the Track One level, and suffered from criticisms related to their legitimacy and inclusiveness. In this regard, the chapter has made two main contributions; one theoretical and one empirical.

The theoretical contribution is to expand the field of conflict resolution by incorporating the literature on ontological security within it. This literature is beginning to produce a valuable framework for analysis in international relations and conflict resolution. Considering ontological security can also help inform policy-making and peace-building by exposing fears and anxieties and locating their causes in order to propose effective ways of transforming relationships.

The empirical contribution focuses on an innovative methodology that relates the theory to practice. The ADN methodology employed by the ENGAGE project focused on involving and opening channels of communication, particularly in rural areas, between “key people and more people” by providing an open and participatory platform for dialogue and deliberation. Rural communities, civil society activists, academics, opinion makers, business people, and central and local authorities came together both mono-communally and bi-communally with the aim of enhancing understanding, trust and reconciliation between the two communities in Cyprus, and of producing a joint and representative policy paper detailing confidence building priorities. These confidence building priorities not only illustrate the operation of the theoretical framework, but also reflect the outcome of efforts towards grassroots reconciliation by documenting initiatives that take nuances of identity and ontological security seriously.

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